

11 Media Servers

This section is specifically very useful for home users who have multiple machines running typically on Wi-Fi backbone.

Let us first answer an increasingly important question, why would you need a media server and how would it differ from a file server if centralisation is the only concern. Let us begin by answering the first question, a centralised location for all your media prevents you from maintain a copy on each machine and syncing them recurrently with addition of new media. Coming to the second question, it is far different and sophisticated than a simple file server as first and foremost it supports streaming (think YouTube), so you don't have to first download a file, watch/listen to it and then delete it, you can simply stream it, and if you implement QoS in your network router you are assured of your bandwidth also. Most media servers support UPnP protocol which enables other network enabled media devices to connect and interact. Universal Plug and Play (UPnP) is a set of networking protocols promulgated by the UPnP Forum. The goals of UPnP are to allow devices to connect seamlessly and to simplify the implementation of networks in the home (data sharing, communications, and entertainment) and in corporate environments for simplified installation of computer components. UPnP achieves this by defining and publishing UPnP device control protocols (DCP) built upon open, internet-based communication standards.

We will be using Jinzora, the PHP-based media server for this specific guide.

11.1 Installing Jinzora Media Server

Jinzora is a web-based media streaming and management system. It is supported in various platforms and it allows you to access your music collection from any devices over the internet. It supports a variety of audio and video formats and even has support for on-the-fly transcoding. Jinzora needs LAMP to be installed on your system, this is dead simple in distributions like Ubuntu, where you can simply go to the synaptics package manager, select packages by task and choose LAMP from there.

One small plugin would be needed in the P or the PHP part of the above, for that simply do the following in your terminal:

```
$ sudo apt-get install php5-gd
$ sudo /etc/init.d/apache2 restart
```

The first command installs the plugin, while the second simply restarts the service.

Next open your `php.ini` or the configuration file to optimise your PHP service and get ready for jinzora, it would be located at `/etc/php5/apache2/php.ini`: You will need root permissions to open this.